



WHAT MIGHT HAVE BEEN:
Karat has a lot to ponder over

BEARING THE BURDEN

- 1** Having staked his all on opposition to the N-deal, Karat now will have to watch the deal unroll and also runs the risk of seeing the BJP back in power
- 2** The Left's new partners are the BSP, TDP, JD(S) and AGP, all ex-BJP allies, a fact that will take some of the sheen off its secular credentials
- 3** Left parties can do nothing but sit back and watch as the reforms and legislations they blocked for four years will be pursued by Government

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poverty, hunger, lack of development and the absence of a voice."

The CPI(M) finds it difficult to explain its decision to vote against the UPA along with the BJP. The party cites the example of Congress teaming up with the BJP to bring down the V.P. Singh Government in 1990 and later "conspiring" to remove the governments of H.D. Deve Gowda in 1997 and I.K. Gujral in 1998 to defend its decision to vote against the Government. But the Left's friend-turned-foe Amar Singh, the SP MP, hits where it hurts most. "*Lal aur lal jhanda saath-saath*," he says referring to BJP leader Lal Krishna Advani and CPI(M)'s red flag.

The relationship with Congress and the caste-based Hindi belt parties have been a matter of long-debate in the CPI(M). The party has not yet taken a position vis-a-vis its relations with the Congress in the future. Veterans like Jyoti Basu are unhappy at Karat's belligerence while deal-

ing with the UPA Government, though in keeping with the party credo, Basu may not make his unhappiness public. Even Prime Minister Manmohan Singh did not spare the opportunity to hit at Karat's alleged isolation within the party. "Our friends in the Left Front should ponder over the company they are forced to keep because of miscalculations by their general secretary," he noted in his politically-loaded speech on the trust motion. "Our Left colleagues should tell us whether L.K. Advani is acceptable to them as a candidate for the post of the prime minister. L.K. Advani should enlighten us if he will step aside as prime ministerial candidate of the Opposition in favour of the UNPA," he said.

It goes to his credit that Karat had resisted, almost single-handedly, the economic reforms and the nuclear deal. "It was the firm stand of the party and the Left that prevented a full-fledged entry of FDI in retail trade, the opening up of the